



From the office of
Commissioner Michael S. Kohler, District Two

Sep 29, 2024

Reconnecting Communities Program
U.S. Department of Transportation
1200 New Jersey Avenue SE
Washington, DC 20590

SUBJ: LETTER OF SUPPORT FOR THE ESCAMBIA BAY WATERFRONT ACCESS STUDY

As Commissioner for Escambia County District 2, I am writing to offer my strong support for Bluffline's Reconnecting Communities Pilot Program grant application. This project represents a transformative opportunity to reconnect the Ferry Pass community in District 4 to essential resources along the Escambia Bay waterfront while simultaneously providing significant economic and transportation benefits for Warrington in District 2, which I represent.

For decades, Ferry Pass has been physically disconnected from the waterfront due to US-90 and the railroad, creating barriers that have restricted residents' access to jobs, education, and recreational opportunities. The Bluffline project seeks to eliminate these barriers by introducing pedestrian pathways and a water taxi service that will directly connect Ferry Pass to key destinations. This improved access is critical for Ferry Pass residents, many of whom are disadvantaged, as it will open economic opportunities and provide easier access to educational institutions such as the University of West Florida (UWF).

The water taxi system will feature terminals at UWF in Ferry Pass and Bayou Chico in Warrington, forming the backbone of the project's transportation network. Importantly, this system creates a two-way connection, with Corry Station, located in Warrington, serving as the primary destination for those traveling from Ferry Pass, and UWF as the main destination for travelers from Warrington. By linking these two crucial economic and educational hubs, the project will enable Ferry Pass residents to access employment and training opportunities at Corry Station and elsewhere within NAS Pensacola, while Warrington residents will gain direct access to the higher education opportunities at UWF. This two-way corridor enhances regional mobility, facilitating economic growth in both communities.

The project is closely aligned with Escambia County's key planning efforts. The Atwood Community Redevelopment Area (CRA) Plan for Ferry Pass calls for improved pedestrian infrastructure, open spaces, and greater connectivity. Bluffline directly addresses these needs by integrating pedestrian pathways with the water taxi system, helping Ferry Pass residents overcome long-standing barriers to access. The Warrington CRA Plan similarly emphasizes creating safer, more accessible



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transportation options for residents, and the inclusion of the Bayou Chico terminal serves as a critical link for residents to access job opportunities and services beyond their immediate area.

Bluffline's contribution to environmental sustainability is another important aspect of the project. In partnership with the Pensacola and Perdido Bays Estuary Program, Bluffline will explore living shorelines and other green infrastructure improvements at Skinner Mill Creek, Chimney Park and Jackson Lakes, benefiting both Ferry Pass and Warrington by enhancing climate resilience and protecting natural habitats. These environmental improvements align with the findings of recent city and county Climate Vulnerability Assessments, making the project a key part of our broader effort to build resilience against climate risks such as flooding and storm surge.

Additionally, this project plays an important role in supporting the long-term viability of NAS Pensacola and Corry Station. The NAS Pensacola Compatible Use Study and the Emerald Coast Military Installation Resiliency Review have identified transportation safety and limited connectivity as challenges to military readiness. Bluffline addresses these issues by providing a safe, efficient connection between Corry Station and civilian neighborhoods, offering military personnel and their families improved access to Ferry Pass, while helping the local economy by connecting residents to job opportunities at the base.

In conclusion, Bluffline is a highly impactful project that will reconnect Ferry Pass and Warrington through a comprehensive transportation network, with UWF and Corry Station serving as its two primary destinations. This initiative will restore access to vital resources for underserved communities, fostering economic growth, enhancing educational opportunities, and promoting environmental resilience in both districts. I strongly urge you to support this grant proposal, as it will have a lasting positive impact on Escambia County and its residents.

Very respectfully,

A handwritten signature in blue ink, appearing to read "Michael S. Kohler", is written over a horizontal line.

Michael S Kohler



From the office of
Commissioner Michael S. Kohler, District Two

Sep 29, 2024

Community Change Program
U.S. Department of Environmental Protection
1200 Pennsylvania Avenue NW
Washington, DC 20004

SUBJ: LETTER OF SUPPORT FOR THE BLUFFLINE JACKSON LAKES EXTENSION

I am writing as the Commissioner of District 2, which includes Warrington, NAS Pensacola, and Jackson Lakes, to express my strong support for The Bluffline's application for the Community Change Grant. This project is critical for enhancing our infrastructure, improving ecological resilience, and supporting educational and military objectives.

In the communities of Brownsville and Warrington, known as "Corridors of Concern," residents face high rates of poverty and low educational attainment. The Bluffline project aims to address these issues by constructing safe, pedestrian-friendly routes to schools like Global Learning Academy and Warrington Preparatory Academy. These routes will enhance student safety, reduce truancy, and improve academic engagement, providing substantial support to some of our most underserved.

The Bluffline project is a cornerstone of the Warrington Community Redevelopment Area (CRA) plan, which focuses on revitalizing the Jackson Lakes area. This revitalization includes creating public green spaces and improving pedestrian infrastructure, which are essential for reducing environmental pollution and advancing climate resilience. These efforts are in alignment with the grant's goals of promoting sustainable community environments and mitigating climate risks.

The project also supports Escambia County's military mission, addressing key vulnerabilities such as blight, transportation safety, and low educational attainment identified in the NAS Pensacola Compatible Use Study and the Emerald Coast Military Installation Resiliency Review. By improving connectivity and transportation options for military and civilian personnel and their families, The Bluffline project enhances the sustainability of our bases, which are vital to the local economy.

By integrating improvements in education, military support, urban renewal, and environmental restoration, The Bluffline project offers a comprehensive model for sustainable community development. It represents a significant step toward transforming one of the most dynamic and diverse areas of Escambia County into a thriving, resilient community. This project not only supports the immediate needs of our residents but also aligns with your grant's objectives to deliver equitable, long-lasting benefits to our communities.

I urge you to provide your full support for this transformative initiative, recognizing its potential to dramatically uplift our district and serve as a beacon for community-driven change. Thank you for considering this vital initiative.

Very Respectfully

A handwritten signature in blue ink that reads "Michael S. Kohler". The signature is fluid and cursive, with the first name "Michael" and last name "Kohler" clearly legible.

Michael S Kohler